In the ensuing years, Alberuni, though he despised Mahmud, remained loosely attached to his court as a resident scholar. The court had other poets and scholars too, including at one time the great Persian poet Firdausi, making Mahmud a kind of patron of the arts (Firdausi, however, had had a falling out with Mahmud and had fled for his life years before Alberuni's involuntary arrival).

The details are murky but Mahmud's raids created opportunities for Alberuni to travel to India, perhaps accompanying a prince of Khiva now serving Mahmud.[6] Until then, everything known in the Turko-Persian-Arabic world about the Hindus, claims Alberuni, was 'second-hand information . . . a farrago of materials never sifted by the sieve of critical examination'. Thereafter, led by his curiosity and with no hope of reward from Mahmud, Alberuni learnt Sanskrit, travelled to many parts of India during his visits, met learned men and spent most of the next thirteen years observing, questioning and studying Indian thought and society.

Around 1030, Alberuni recorded his findings in a monumental work with an arresting title, *Taḥqīq mā li-l-hind min maqūlah maqbūlah fī al-ʿaql aw mardhūlah* or 'Verifying All That the Indians Recount, the Reasonable and the Unreasonable'.[7] Alberuni wrote this work to provide, in his own words, 'the essential facts for any Muslim who wanted to converse with Hindus and to discuss with them questions of religion, science, or literature'. It was translated from Arabic to English as *Alberuni's India* by Edward C. Sachau in 1888, still the only translation available.

Alberuni was a mildly devout Muslim, likely Shia, with modest pride in the Persian culture of Islam. He was remarkably open-minded, well informed, and a big believer in science, reason and evidence. He couldn't stand humbug, writes Sachau, claiming that on 'the horrid practices of Rasayana, i.e. the art of making gold, of making old people young, etc., he bursts out into sarcastic words which are more coarse in the original than in my translation'.

We know almost nothing about Alberuni's early life or family. He grew up without a father and was likely a bachelor all his life. He was a child of the so-called Golden Age of Islam, when science and cosmopolitan culture thrived in Baghdad and other cities of Western Asia. His other eminent near-contemporaries were Avicenna, Alhazen and Omar Khayyam.[8] A